

who can think of the second- and third-order effects stand to make a fortune.

9. “Never attempt to teach a pig to sing; it wastes your time and annoys the pig.”—Robert A. Heinlein, *The Notebooks of Lazarus Long*

I have been writing in public for 25 years. I often get pushback to what I publish. In response, I correct factual errors or share new data. But I will never be able to change a person’s deeply held, fundamental belief system. They have invested too much time and energy in their worldview, and it would be way too cognitively expensive for them to reverse that.

David McRaney explains the challenges of persuading people to change beliefs or opinions: It is very difficult to do, especially where their self-identity is involved.^{[118](#)}

Or as Heinlein observed: “Man is not a rational animal; he is a rationalizing animal.”

10. “*Memento Mori*” (Latin for “remember that you will die”)

At the end of the day, we all shuffle off this mortal coil to our infinite repose.

The Stoic philosopher Marcus Aurelius urged us to “consider how ephemeral and mean all mortal things are.” He used the example of a triumphant Roman general: He had a companion stand behind him during his victory procession and whisper “*Memento Mori*” to remind him of his own mortality.^{[119](#)}

On a long enough timescale, everything is transitory. As we work our way through the detritus and minutia of life, we should not lose sight of that.



These ideas have influenced me the most. Despite the bad advice out there,